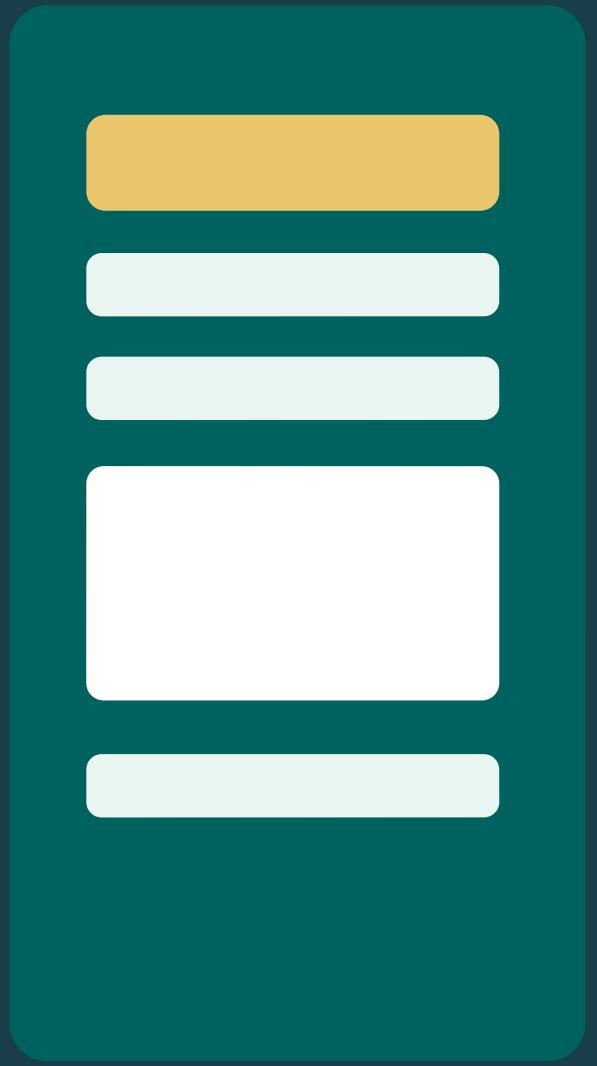
IIA / WEB DESIGN

PRINCIPLES OF GOOD WEB DESIGN

Designing usable, clear and accessible websites for libraries and records services.



UNIT 02 • STUDENT LECTURE SLIDES

Learning outcomes

After this unit, you should be able to make simple, defensible design decisions.

Explain

Describe why a usable website must help visitors complete tasks—not only look attractive.

Organise

Identify likely visitors, content groups and understandable navigation labels.

Design

Use hierarchy, typography, spacing, contrast and responsive thinking.

Evaluate

Draw a wireframe and suggest practical improvements to a website.

A website is a service, not a decoration

The quality of design is measured partly by the visitor’s experience.

Attractive ≠ effective

A beautiful library homepage is not useful if students cannot find the catalogue or opening hours.

Useful design

Put common tasks in clear locations, use familiar language and make important actions visible.

KEY IDEA · Ask: Can a visitor achieve their purpose without unnecessary effort?

Understand your visitors

Start with real questions about people and their needs.

WHO uses this website?

Library visitors may be students, lecturers and researchers. Records visitors may be staff or authorised requesters.

WHAT will they do?

Look up hours, search resources, read a procedure or find the right contact. Prioritise frequent, important tasks.

KEY IDEA · Design for the user’s context, including mobile devices and limited connectivity.

A small user-task table

Identify a user, their task and the information they require.

Student	Check opening hours	Hours clearly visible
Researcher	Find digital journals	A labelled resources link
Records requester	Understand eligibility	Public request procedure
Registry officer	Find retention policy	Organised staff resources

What is usability?

Usability concerns effective, efficient and satisfactory use.

A usable interface

The website tells visitors where they are, makes actions predictable, and communicates errors clearly.

An unusable interface

Unclear menus, hidden details, tiny text and inconsistent navigation make ordinary tasks harder.

KEY IDEA · Try to complete one important task as a first-time visitor.

Consistency reduces confusion

Visitors should not need to relearn the interface on each page.

Position

Keep main navigation in a familiar location throughout the website.

Words

Use the same name for the same service: “Catalogue” should not become “Resources Hub” unexpectedly.

Appearance

Use consistent heading styles, button designs and spacing.

Behaviour

Similar controls should respond in similar, understandable ways.

Information architecture

Group content and name it so visitors can find it.

Information architecture

The structure and labelling of pages, topics and relationships. It answers: “Where should this information belong?”

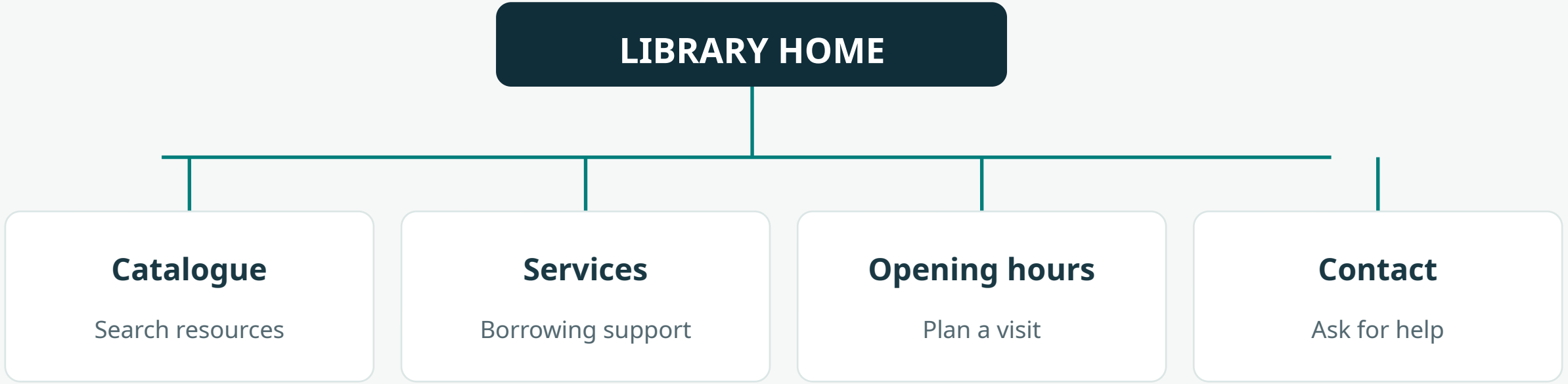
Sitemap and navigation

A sitemap shows page relationships. Navigation provides links people follow between those pages.

KEY IDEA · A clear structure usually matters more than an elaborate visual theme.

Example: a simple library sitemap

The homepage points to a small set of predictable destinations.



KEY IDEA · Descriptive labels reduce guessing.

Choose labels users understand

A menu is part of the website’s communication.

Unclear labels

“Knowledge Discovery Interface”, “Client Retrieval Transactions” and “Miscellaneous” make visitors guess.

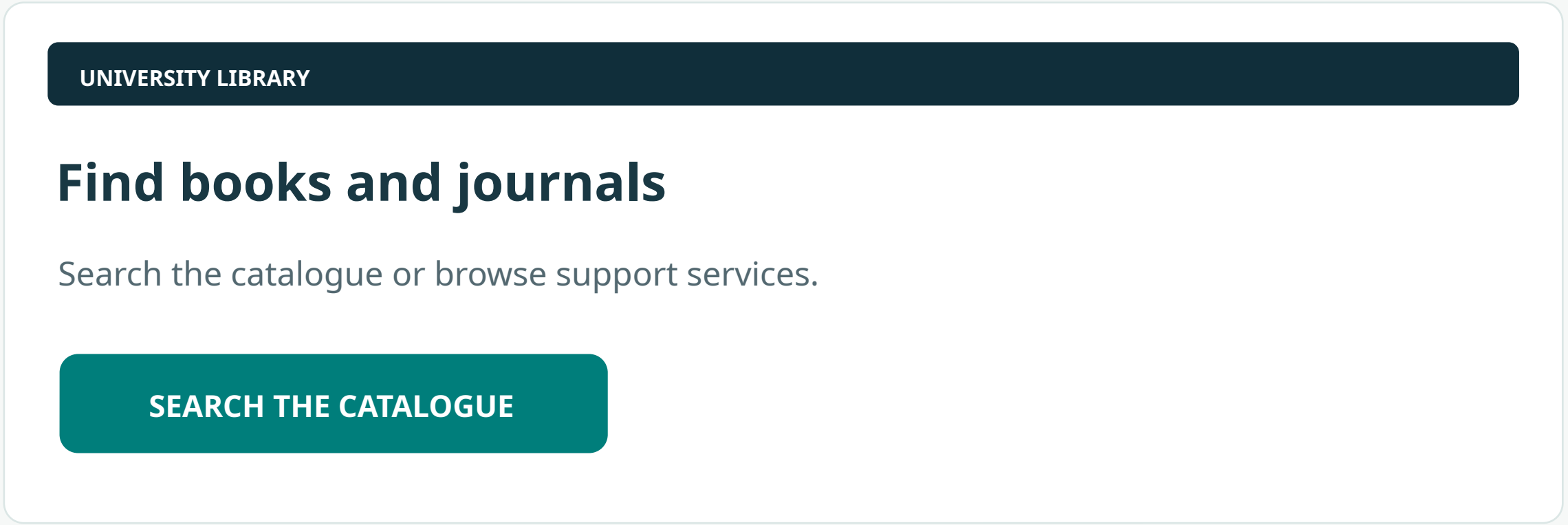
Clear labels

“Catalogue”, “Request a Record”, “Opening Hours” and “Contact” explain what visitors will find.

KEY IDEA · Use the visitor’s vocabulary rather than internal office jargon.

Visual hierarchy: what is noticed first?

Size, position, contrast and spacing help visitors notice important actions.



Use whitespace deliberately

Empty space helps people see relationships and read comfortably.

Crowded layout

Many controls, announcements and paragraphs pushed together compete for attention.

Grouped content

Place related items together. Separate major sections and give headings room to stand out.

KEY IDEA · Whitespace is a design tool—not an empty space to fill.

Readable typography

Text is a major part of an information service.

Make text readable

Use appropriate text sizes, clear typefaces, reasonable line lengths and comfortable line spacing.

Use a heading structure

A meaningful page title and descriptive subheadings help people scan. Avoid long paragraphs in ALL CAPS.

KEY IDEA · Prioritise legibility over decorative fonts.

Colour and contrast

Text must remain clearly distinguishable from its background.

LOW CONTRAST

Opening hours
Monday–Friday, 08:00–18:00

GOOD CONTRAST

Opening hours
Monday–Friday, 08:00–18:00

KEY IDEA · Do not rely on colour alone to convey meaning.

Links, buttons and forms

The visitor should know what will happen next.

Clear actions

“Download borrowing guidelines (PDF)” is more informative than “Click here.” Links navigate; buttons trigger actions.

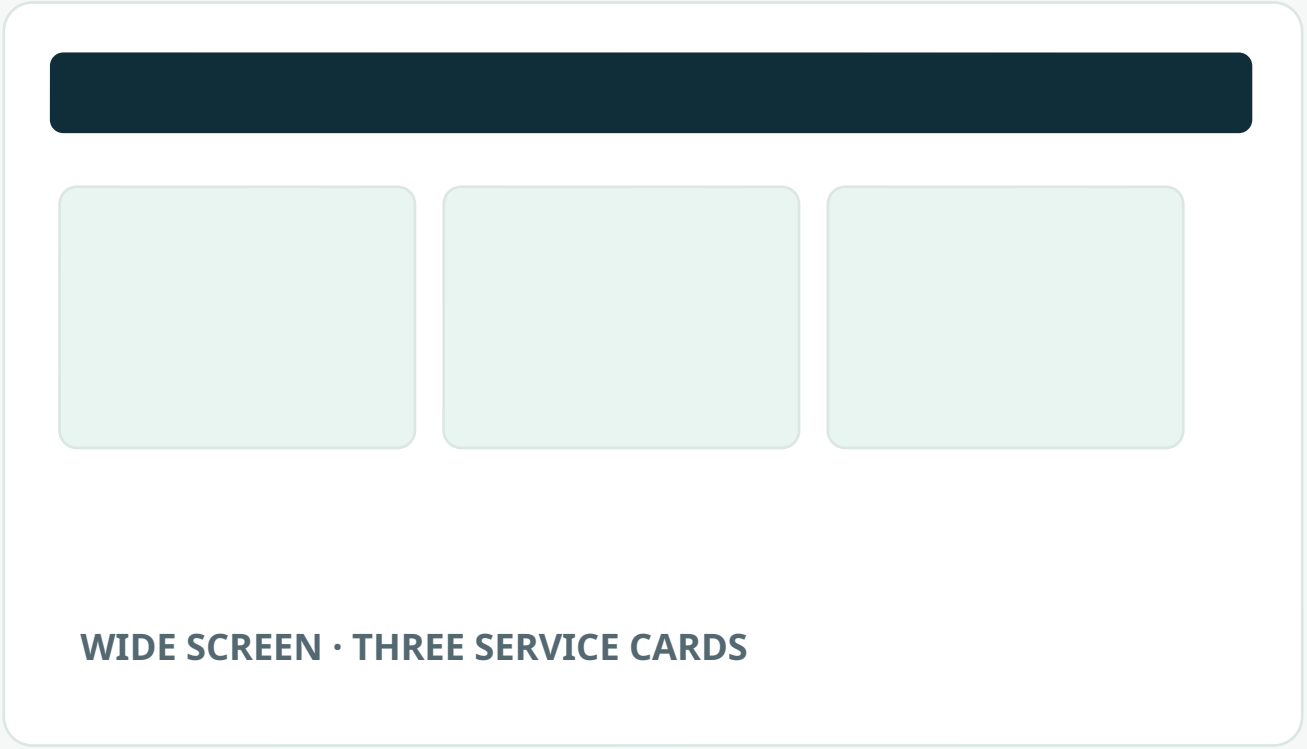
Clear data requests

Use visible field labels, explain required information and show meaningful error messages.

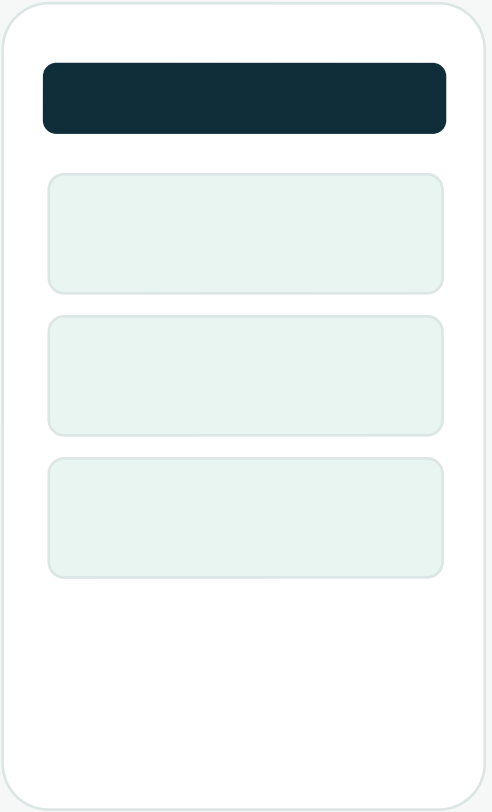
KEY IDEA · Real records requests require appropriate security and access controls.

Design for screens of different sizes

A usable layout adapts without hiding essential tasks.



WIDE SCREEN · THREE SERVICE CARDS



PHONE · STACKED CARDS

Accessibility benefits more visitors

Accessibility means content can be perceived, understood and operated by people with differing abilities.

Clear headings

Organise pages into descriptive sections that people and assistive technologies can follow.

Keyboard support

Links and buttons should be usable without a mouse; focus should remain visible.

Image descriptions

Give informative images meaningful alternative text; decoration need not be announced.

Multiple cues

Combine text and visual cues. Never indicate an error only through red colour.

A practical accessibility example

Think about visitors using a phone, magnification or screen reader.

Problem

Library hours are published only in a photograph of a noticeboard. Some visitors cannot read the tiny text or interpret the image.

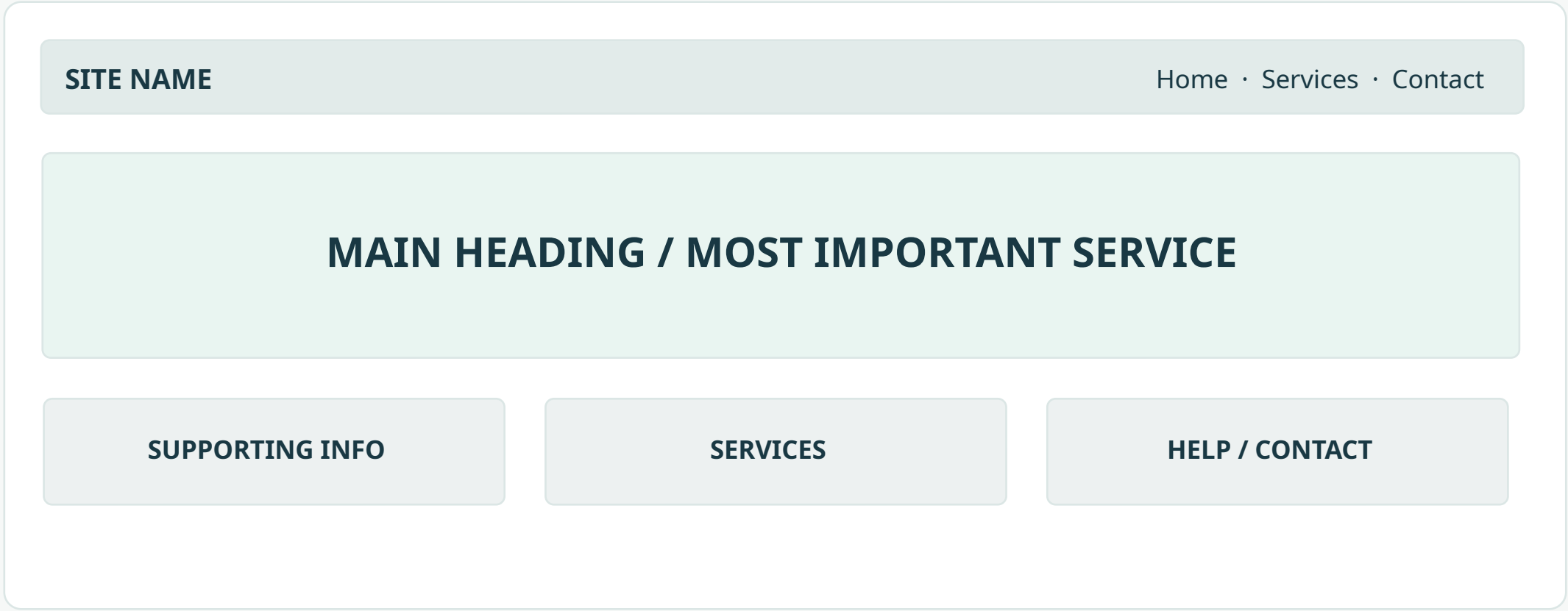
Improvement

Write the hours as ordinary webpage text. If the image conveys extra information, supply an appropriate text alternative.

KEY IDEA · Include accessibility from the first sketch, not just at the end.

A wireframe is a webpage blueprint

Sketch the layout first; decide colours and HTML details later.



Library design scenario

The page should make frequently used services easy to find.

Visitors and tasks

Students and researchers need catalogue access, electronic resources, opening hours and borrowing guidance.

Homepage priorities

Place search prominently. Keep hours and borrowing information easy to scan. Use familiar navigation labels.

KEY IDEA · Reason: the homepage should support resource discovery.

Records-management scenario

Public guidance and restricted records must be handled differently.

Visitors and tasks

Authorised requesters need instructions, eligibility information, service hours and a contact channel.

Homepage priorities

Make procedures and help visible. Do not expose sensitive inventories or personal files on a public page.

KEY IDEA · Reason: clarity and confidentiality must work together.

A poor homepage versus an improved one

Which one makes the visitor’s main task obvious?

Before

Unclear heading: “Discover Information Excellence”. Menu: Resources, Other, Misc. Opening hours are hidden in a long text block.

After

Clear heading: “Search the Library Catalogue”. Menu: Catalogue, Services, Hours, Contact. A search action is visible.

KEY IDEA · The improvement is about finding information, not merely changing colours.

Evaluate a website in five checks

Open a public information-service website and answer each question.

1. **Can I tell what this website provides?**
2. Can I find its most important service?
3. Are the menu labels familiar and clear?
4. Is the text easy to read?
5. Can I use it on a narrow screen?

From problem to recommendation

A specific change is more useful than a vague opinion.

Observation

“The archive website uses the menu label Client Retrieval Transactions. Visitors may not know what this means.”

Recommendation

“Rename it Request a Record, because this tells visitors what they can do without knowing internal terminology.”

KEY IDEA · State the issue, the change and the benefit to users.

Practical: draw a homepage wireframe

Use paper and a pen, or a simple digital drawing tool.

1. Choose

Create a fictional library or records-centre website.

2. Identify

Write two target users and two tasks they want to complete.

3. Sketch

Show website name, menu, main task, supporting links and footer.

4. Check

Explain what a first-time visitor would notice first and why.

Small individual assignment

Keep the product short and manageable.

One-page submission

Draw one homepage wireframe for a fictional library or records centre. Hand-drawn or digital is fine.

Three explanations

Name two main user tasks and write three short sentences explaining layout, navigation and the primary action.

KEY IDEA · Submit one photograph or PDF when the submission link is announced.

Review: six principles worth remembering

Use these as a checklist when you plan any information-service website.

1. People

Design for real visitors and their tasks.

2. Structure

Group content and label it clearly.

3. Hierarchy

Make important information noticeable.

4. Readability

Use clear text, spacing and contrast.

5. Inclusion

Support different abilities and screen sizes.

6. Privacy

Protect confidential information.

Next: turn the plan into HTML

Good web design comes before, during and after writing code.

In Unit 3, you will learn how an HTML document is structured. You will use headings, paragraphs, lists and links to turn a simple information-service plan into a working webpage.

Bring your wireframe: it is the first step towards a real website.

Independent reading and revision

The lesson notes contain fuller explanations, case studies and an interactive wireframe.

W3C Web Accessibility Initiative

Read introductory guidance on accessible pages: understandable content, keyboard use, text alternatives and colour contrast. Visit w3.org/WAI/.

MDN Web Development

Explore introductory web design and responsive design explanations at developer.mozilla.org/en-US/docs/Learn_web_development/.

KEY IDEA · Complete the 8-question quiz in the online Unit 2 page to check your learning.